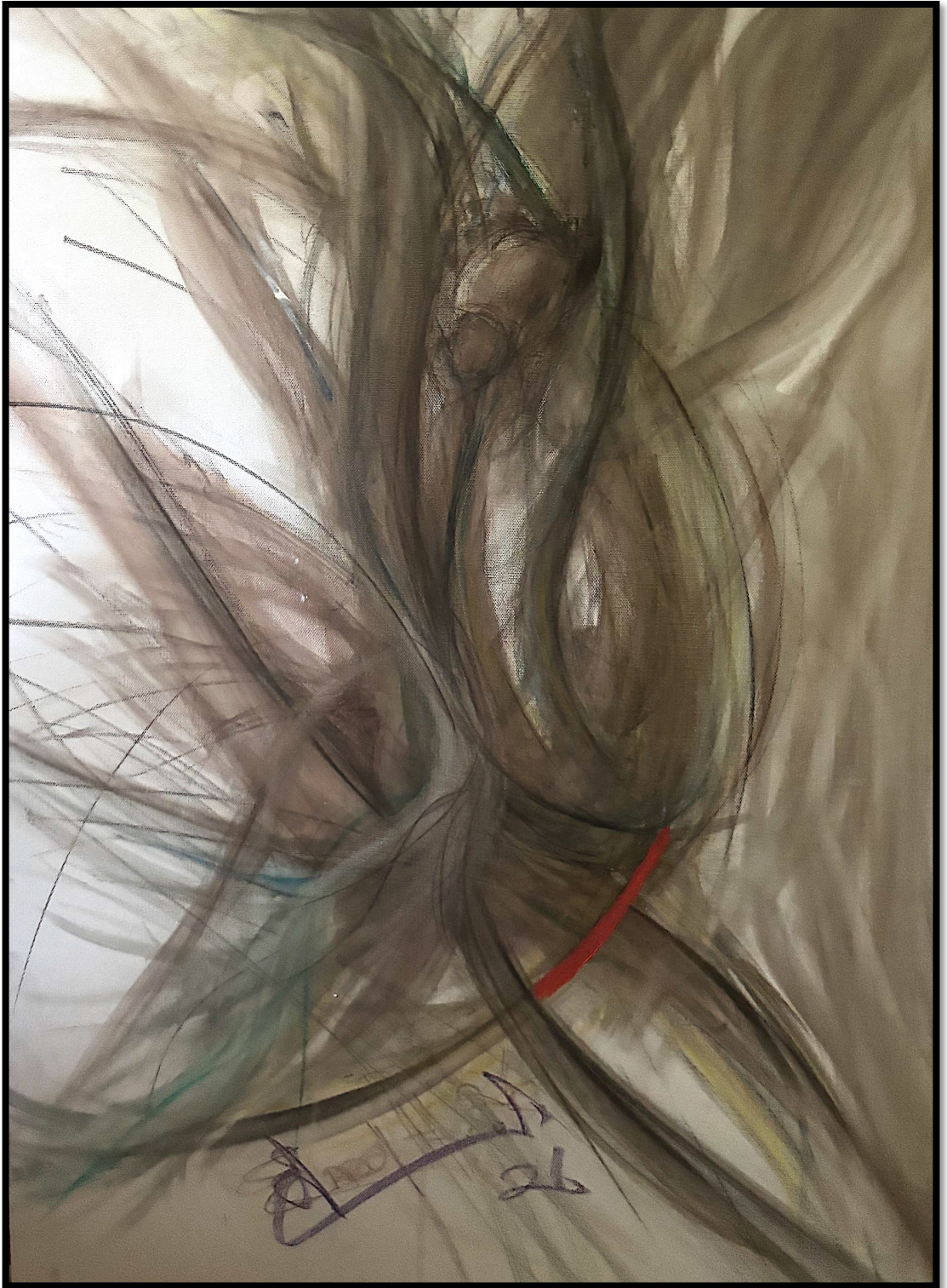




Chapter One



THE SILENCE

"I did not disappear. I just became difficult to see."

People often ask where I went.

Some ask directly. Others ask through former colleagues, mutual acquaintances or fragments of conversations carried between people who once knew me. Many simply assume that I moved on, changed careers or chose a different path.

The truth is more complicated. I did not disappear overnight. I disappeared gradually. At first there were fewer conversations. Fewer professional engagements. Fewer invitations. Fewer reasons to leave the house.

Then came the silence. The loss of my professional registration did not arrive as a single event. It arrived as a series of consequences that continued to unfold long after the official process had ended. The public record contains findings, procedures and outcomes. My lived experience was something very different.

It was waking each morning with a sense of dread before my feet touched the floor.

It was the sound of the letterbox and the immediate fear of what might be waiting on the other side of the door.

It was unopened correspondence gathering in piles because I no longer possessed the emotional resources to deal with another demand, another threat, another reminder of what my life had become.

Each envelope carried the possibility of bad news. Another debt. Another court order. Another consequence. Another loss.

The complaint did not simply take away my registration.

It left me trying to defend my livelihood, my reputation, my housing, my finances and my mental health, all at the same time and largely on my own.

People often assume that professional disciplinary proceedings end when a decision is reached.

My experience was different.

The decision was not the end.

In many ways, it was the beginning.

The loss of work brought financial hardship.

Financial hardship brought instability.

Instability brought isolation.

Isolation brought despair.

Each consequence fed the next until it became difficult to separate one loss from another.

The profession I had devoted years of my life to was gone.

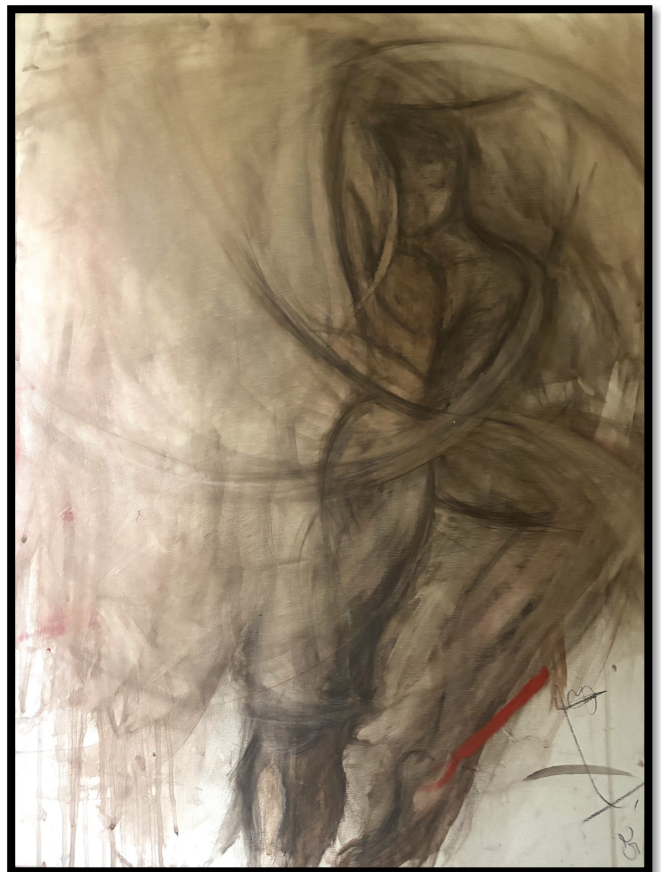
The identity I had built around that profession began to disappear with it.

I was no longer introducing myself as a psychotherapist.

I was no longer planning a future within the profession I loved.

I was no longer the person I had spent decades becoming.

What remained was uncertainty.





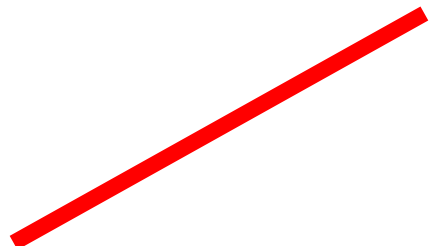
The future that I had imagined for myself dissolved.

The practical realities became increasingly difficult to ignore. Debt accumulated. Income disappeared. Housing became insecure. Every application seemed to require explanations. Every new beginning seemed overshadowed by what had come before. There is a particular kind of exhaustion that comes from living under constant pressure. Not physical exhaustion. Existential exhaustion. The exhaustion of carrying shame.. The exhaustion of defending yourself in conversations that no one else remembers. The exhaustion of trying to rebuild while still grieving what has been lost. There were periods when I withdrew almost completely. The world became smaller. Phone calls went unanswered. Messages remained unread.

Relationships drifted. Not because I no longer cared, but because survival required every ounce of energy I possessed. Many people misunderstand silence.

They assume it is indifference. They assume it is avoidance. They assume it means a person has accepted their circumstances and moved on. My silence was none of those things. My silence was grief. My silence was exhaustion. My silence was the sound of a person trying to survive. As the years passed, the weight of that struggle became increasingly difficult to bear.

There were times when I questioned whether I could continue. Times when the losses felt so overwhelming that I could no longer imagine a future beyond them. The shame became corrosive. The uncertainty became relentless. The isolation became unbearable. Eventually, I reached a point of profound despair. A point at which I no longer believed there was a way forward. I came dangerously close to losing my life. The tribunal took away my registration. The years that followed very nearly took away everything else. Yet somehow, I remained. Not because I was strong. Not because I had answers. Not because I had accepted what had happened as I have evidence to prove how bias and flawed my case was. I somehow remained somewhere beneath



The grief, the fear and the exhaustion there was still a small part of me that refused to disappear entirely. That part of me found its way into paint. The works that accompany this chapter emerged during those years. They were not created as evidence. They were not created for exhibition. They were created because words alone were no longer sufficient. The paintings became witnesses. They recorded what I could not always say. The figures appear and disappear. They emerge from darkness and dissolve back into it. Like me, they exist somewhere between presence and absence. They are the visual language of a life lived in silence. They ask the same question that I continue to ask today: What becomes of a person when everything that once defined them has been taken away?

The answer, imperfect as it may be, is this:

They remain.

Changed.

Wounded.

Uncertain.

But somehow still here ■

